

COMP 3700A: Contributing to Open Source

Exploring FOSS communities (continued)

Charlotte Curtis

September 23, 2026

Housekeeping

- Do we have notetakers for [today's topics](#)?
 - Goal is to have the PR for each topic submitted within **1 week**
 - After submission, I will add a reviewer — you may request specific topic
 - If you are chosen as reviewer, you may decline the invitation
- Lab 3: I invited everyone with an open PR to have "maintainer" privileges

Today's Goals

- A few more comments on licensing
- Pick up where we were interrupted with the fire alarm!
 - Common documents ✓
 - Project activity
 - Communication channels
- Understand the various roles in FOSS communities
- Non-code contributions (if we have time...)

I will use [Inkscape](#) and [QBittorrent](#) as examples. Please pick 1-2 others to look at and answer questions during this class.

Licence considerations

- When you contribute to a project, you typically [agree to the license](#)
- There may even be a [contributor license agreement](#)
- Every source has bias! For example, [Codeberg](#) vs GitHub
- Mixing licenses can be [tricky](#)

In general, you should be aware of the license for your project, but most of the time you probably won't be affected by it

Evaluating project activity

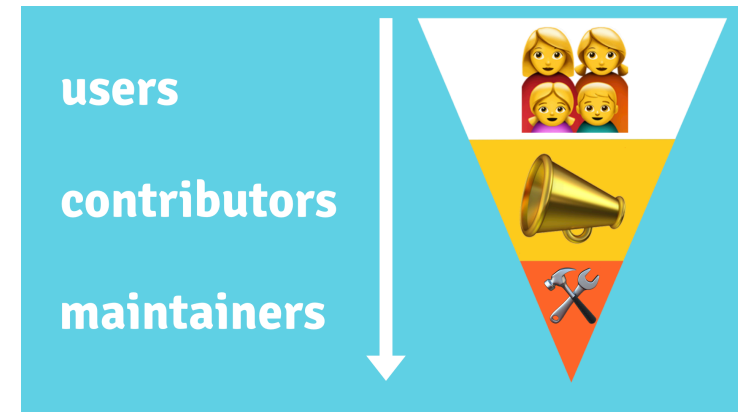
- Issues (GitHub) or Work Items (GitLab) are "to do" items
- Pull/merge requests are accomplishing the "to dos"
- Consider:
 - Which items get closed and why
 - Which get lots of comments
 - Age of open items
 - Tags
- What are the official communication channels, and how often do people post?



How active are the projects?
What communication
channels are most used?

Roles in FOSS projects

- You are already a **user** — might submit bug report
- This semester, you will become a **contributor**:
 - Reproduce bugs
 - Write code, documentation, translations
 - Someone will review your submission
- **Maintainers** are the project leaders who review and merge PRs, manage releases, etc
- The **bus factor** in FOSS is often very low!





What are the key roles? Who are the people in these roles?

Non-code contributions

- At a certain scale, FOSS projects need all kinds of expertise
- Documentation in its [various forms](#)
- UI/UX designers
- Translators
- Bug reporters and triagers

Homework: [Find and post](#) an example of a non-code contribution